

Chapter 5 — Karma-Sannyāsa Yoga

कर्मसंन्यासयोगः : కర్మసన్యాసయోగము

"The Yoga of Renunciation of Action" · 29 verses · Renounce in action, not from it

Arjuna asks again: "Which is better — to renounce action or to perform it?"

Kṛṣṇa's answer in Ch 5 is decisive: **both paths reach the same goal**, but **karma-yoga (action without ego) is easier than karma-sannyāsa (giving up action altogether)**. The wise one is the one who **acts without claiming the action as his own** — who sees the same Self in all beings, and who lives free of attraction and aversion. This chapter introduces the **brahma-bhūta** sage — one who has become Brahman.

Essential verses of Chapter 5

BG 5.18 Equal vision — the wise see the same Self in all

विद्याविनयसम्पन्ने ब्राह्मणे गवि हस्तिनि ।

शुनि चैव श्वपाके च पण्डिताः समदर्शिनः ॥ ५.१८ ॥

విద్యావినయసంపన్నే బ్రాహ్మణే గవి హస్తిని ।

శుని చైవ శ్వపాకే చ పండితాః సమదర్శినః ॥ ౫.౧౮ ॥

vidyā-vinaya-sampanne brāhmaṇe gavi hastini |

śuni caiva śva-pāke ca paṇḍitāḥ sama-darśinaḥ ||

"In a learned and humble brāhmaṇa, in a cow, in an elephant,
in a dog, and in a dog-eater — the wise see the same."

samadarśinaḥ — equal vision: the deliberate refusal to classify beings as higher and lower.

Word-by-Word — 5.18 (equal vision)

IAST	वर्णमाला	संक्षेप	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
<i>vidyā-vinaya-sampanne</i>	विद्याविनयसम्पन्ने	विद్యాविनयसंपन्ने	vid-YAA-vi-NA-ya-sam-PAN-ne	in one endowed with learning and humility
<i>brāhmaṇe</i>	ब्राह्मणे	ब्राह्मणे	BRAAH-ma-ne	in a brāhmaṇa (priest)
<i>gavi</i>	गवि	गवि	GA-vi	in a cow
<i>hastini</i>	हस्तिनि	हस्तिनि	HAS-ti-ni	in an elephant
<i>śuni</i>	शुनि	शुनि	SHU-ni	in a dog
<i>ca eva</i>	च एव	च एव	cha E-va	and also
<i>śva-pāke</i>	श्वपाके	श्वपाके	SHVA-paa-ke	in a dog-eater (an outcaste)
<i>paṇḍitāḥ</i>	पण्डिताः	पंडिताः	PAN-di-taah	the wise ones
<i>sama-darśinaḥ</i>	समदर्शिनः	समदरशिनः	SA-ma-DAR-shi-nah	are equal-visioned, see the same

ये हि संस्पर्शजा भोगा दुःखयोनय एव ते ।
आद्यन्तवन्तः कौन्तेय न तेषु रमते बुधः ॥ ५.२२ ॥

యే హి సంస్పర్శజా భోగా దుఃఖయోనయ ఏవ తే ।
ఆద్యంతవంతః కౌంతేయ న తేషు రమతే బుధః ॥ ౫.౨౨ ॥

ye hi saṁsparśa-jā bhogā duḥkha-yonaya eva te |
ādy-antavantah kaunteya na teṣu ramate budhaḥ |

"The pleasures born of sense-contact are wombs of suffering —
they have a beginning and an end, O Kaunteya.
The wise do not delight in them."

भोक्तारं यज्ञतपसां सर्वलोकमहेश्वरम् ।
सुहृदं सर्वभूतानां ज्ञात्वा मां शान्तिमृच्छति ॥ ५.२९ ॥
భోక్తారం యజ్ఞతపసాం సర్వలోకమహేశ్వరమ్ ।
సుహృదం సర్వభూతానాం జ్ఞాత్వా మాం శాంతిమృచ్ఛతి ॥ ౫.౨౯ ॥

bhoktāraṁ yajña-tapasāṁ sarva-loka-maheśvaram |
suhṛdaṁ sarva-bhūtānāṁ jñātvā māṁ śāntim ṛcchati |

"Knowing Me as the enjoyer of all sacrifices and austerities,
the great Lord of all the worlds,
the friend of all beings — one attains peace."
suhṛdaṁ sarva-bhūtānām — "the friend of all beings" — one of the most tender phrases in the Gītā.

□ Essential take-away of Chapter 5

Renounce inside, not outside.

True renunciation is not abandoning the work; it is abandoning the **ego-claim** on the work. The sage acts but says, "*I am not doing — the senses move among sense-objects.*"

Three marks of the inner sage:

1. **Equal vision** (5.18) — sees the same Self in everyone, from priest to outcaste.
2. **Inner freedom** (5.22) — doesn't seek lasting joy in fleeting pleasures.
3. **Knowing the Lord as friend** (5.29) — sees the Divine as *suhṛd*, friend of all.